

Regarding the Closure of the PMA Library
Written by Nicholas Payan Inzunza
April 2026

Dear Dr. Vanden Bout,

It is important that you know what information we know. Dr. Laguna claimed that UT admin (which according to him could be you or someone else) conducted "some kind of study" (his words) and from this they concluded that the PMA library needed to be removed. As such, he was satisfied with the manner in which the decision was made, i.e. that it was "top-down" and not "bottom-up", as he put it. When asked about the details of such a study or the data, he said that he did not see it. He also mentioned that the creation of offices for the Center for Gravitational Physics, to which he belongs, did not influence the decision, but just that he "saw an opportunity and took it", that the plans for renovation were first put forward and once they were solidified he gave them an extra purpose on his own. All of this being said, we would also like to emphasize that Dr. Laguna informed us that he intentionally kept the plans entirely to himself, for on March 25th, we questioned him as to why he did not tell us about the plan when we directly asked him about it in a graduate student town hall meeting on February 6th amid rumors that the PMA library might close; he neither confirmed nor denied that it would happen at the time, so he replied (on March 25th) that he had to keep it a secret. Likewise, this project was not brought up with the other departmental chairs, those of Mathematics and Astronomy, directly, as we have come to learn, but they have nonetheless endorsed it both verbally and in silence.

Though I express every word here on behalf of myself, after talking with many graduate students and collecting over 1000 signatures on a petition from students, faculty, staff, and alumni (whose signatures and contents we have delivered to you and other administrators), I feel that the following views reflect, at least in some capacity, those of many others in and out of PMA, graduate students or otherwise. At the very least, I argue

here as best as I can for the books to stay within PMA, and my hope is, in light of the fact that all those who signed the petition oppose the decision and would have the library stay as it is were they to have any say, that my words may carry some weight to them.

Below, we deconstruct the reasons that we can extrapolate from the given information as to why the decision was made, addressing the creation of the offices for the Center for Gravitational Physics separately; then, we directly express our reasons for the library books to remain, these being more of a voicing of opinions rather than a strictly logical breakdown. Finally, the entire letter is briefly summarized in the conclusion.

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| Deconstructing the March 24th Email Announcement |
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To start, we find your email lacking in clear verbiage, as we are left with many lingering questions after reading it. Your words barely allude to the reasons for the renovation of the space and give no concrete plans; we find your lack of a call for input even more upsetting than this. We are left to guess as to why this is happening, as all you offer is that circulation has decreased over the years, and you do not explicitly connect this trend with your identification of the supposed need for more space. The remainder of what we can extrapolate from your email comes from Dr. Laguna.

In order to proceed, we must list the inferred assumptions: (the first assumption is threefold) (1) (a) there is a need for (i) study areas and (ii) offices in PMA, (iii) and there is a lack of space for them, (b) AND the best place for them is in the space inhabited by the PMA library (c) BECAUSE (in part) "usage" is declining; (2) the definition of "usage" is that books are checked out at the circulation desk; (3) the benefits that come with the creation of space outweigh any negative impacts which moving the books causes. This is the foundation of any discourse that follows, but if there is anything wrong or missing from this list of assumptions, then please inform us.

Disappointingly, this is ALL that we can infer without speculation. There are many important questions which naturally arise out of your announcement, such as: how long will the renovations take? Will the new study space retain the computers, printers, and scanners? Will the space be quiet or collaborative? What is the layout of the new space and how does it serve students in a way which is better than the ways that the current study space already does? And why? (etc. etc.) The fact that none of these questions can be answered by your email suggests that the outcome was decided before it was given any justification, and it is crucial that the benefits of this project be explicitly stated with proper reasoning or that they are somehow self-evident, for otherwise one questions the entire basis on which the decision was made.

Of course, making any decision such as this should require some reasons for doing so, and as your email suggests, this begins out of a "need", as you put it, for study areas and offices. Looking at the former of these two, such a necessity must emerge from scarcity and saturation, since given that there exist many study spaces on campus and within PMA, then lack of availability could only be implied by an overpopulation of

students crowding the spaces and not from the campus or building itself lacking in a number of such spaces; for if there is ample space for any student in any study space (which there is) then there is no NEED to make MORE of it. One only need walk into the library at ANY given hour in order to see that there are plenty of seats and tables available. To construct this "need", one MUST start as we have, for otherwise the outcome of renovations is increasingly disconnected from the population whom it claims to serve and consequently must service some secondary purpose whose benefits are less direct; i.e. that the "need" would not have arisen out of literal student needs. For example, the need for creation of more study space could mean that the building should look newer, cleaner, or more "inviting", or perhaps that it should meet some quota such as a ratio of study space to classroom square footage, or that books are fire hazards (or any other reasons one could invent); yet we cannot remove any primary purposes for the renovation while granting you some auxiliary ones to replace them since we must weigh this decision as having the greatest direct impact to the greatest amount of people in order to make sense of any cost-benefit analysis motivating it (additionally, your email does not point to the existence of any other reasons for renovation), so we can only conclude as we have done, that this "need" can only exist if there is not enough study space in the library as it is, which we do not agree is true.

Now, having said all of this, let us continue by ASSUMING that such a need does exist, that there is a lack of space for students to study on campus AND that we would like to create such a space within PMA. Let us also assume that this space would be open to any and all students on campus (and it is safe to say that this would be the case). Then, of course, we must ask ourselves why PMA in particular would be the best location for adding new study space for the general body of students and NOT particularly for Physics, Mathematics, and Astronomy students only. Is it because there is a lack of study space on the north side of campus (despite the fact that the Geosciences and Engineering libraries were likewise cleared for renovations last semester)? Is it PMA itself that is easiest to renovate? etc. Your email does not even hint at answers to any such questions. Thus, like the existence of a "need" for study space, that PMA specifically MUST be the site of the new study space cannot be constructed from information within your email nor that which was disseminated by Dr. Laguna, and we have no choice but to blindly assume that it should be as such. In this repeated exercise of assuming that the assertions leading to this decision were true rather than coming to such conclusions on our own, it can only look from the outset as though PMA was chosen as a location first, THEN some extrinsic (rather than intrinsic) motivating factors were created to justify this.

To reiterate, we are assuming the following: that there exists a need for study space for UT students (not just Physics, Mathematics, and Astronomy students) and that PMA is the best location for such space. Even granting you this, further inspection continues to elucidate logical inconsistencies within your decision. Work must be done to justify why the library books must be removed in order to accomplish the creation of this study space, and it will take at least two steps: first, it must be shown that the PMA library in particular should have more study space, and second, that the removal of the books is required in order to create that space. Both of these steps are necessary because it is not immediately obvious that the library facility should have more study space (partly because there is enough space to accommodate the current amount of students that use it), but it is easy enough to see that any new space intended for students inside and

outside of the PMA departments should probably be on the fourth floor, as it is the most easily accessible. Although, we find that since many of the classrooms on the fifth, sixth, and seventh floors are not in constant use, that one could free up space by properly scheduling class and discussion times, i.e. that if there are X classes in PMA, Y hours of the day to hold them, and Z number of classrooms, that Y times Z is greater than X. Yet, however constrained the space on the fourth floor is, the library is not the only viable option for the creation of new study space. The lobby area preceding the elevators in front of the library has similar square footage to the space taken up by the stacks, so extending the library into this area could accomplish your goal. The library could likewise be extended to encompass the offices behind the elevator and those offices themselves could be moved into whatever new office space you might create on the fifth floor (we will return to talking about the fifth floor and new office spaces later). Yet in coming up with ideas, we are of course avoiding the obvious fact that moving the library books is simply the EASIEST solution to the problem of adding space, that the space is already there but it is being taken up by books. We consider the difficulties that might come in retaining the books to be worth it (very much so) if it only means that we must undertake a slightly larger construction project.

In your email you give incentive to remove the books by saying that because circulation has been declining, then it is okay to move the books outside of the building. From this information, we can only conclude that you take the purpose of a library to be the following: that one might need information from a particular book which they know **a priori**, so they go to the library to find this book, and if the book is there then they check it out at the circulation desk. Many identify with this alternative usage: that one has a general topic in mind that they wish to know more about, they find a section of the library which may host books containing that information, and they peruse through various volumes until they find one or more that might particularly suit them, which they may or may not decide to check out depending on the situation; this is a very common way to use a library. It is clear that you define a library's usage so narrowly as we have laid out above, for in the former definition, moving the books does not obstruct library usage, yet it does so in the latter. In accepting that browsing is important to the usage of a library, then you understand that proximity of books is a necessity for regular browsing. By moving the books you remove a core function of the book collection. Obviously, if the books are as far as the tower or off campus, then it is extremely improbable that people will be as motivated to browse the collections; indeed, it is likely that the habit which many possess of browsing the stacks will be lost entirely. Your decision has a unique scenario in which it is maximally logical, being that it does not disrupt usage of the library collections, and this is solely achieved by taking the definition of a library's purpose to be that first one which we have described.

Yet even as such, it is impossible to assess your decision in a vacuum, for it places barriers on book accessibility, and inextricably so, even given some ideal definition of library usage. The state of maximal accessibility is undeniably that which we currently possess, so there will always be a decline in accessibility in executing this decision. Thus, if one is to attribute the current circumstance as being ideally beneficial, then removal of the books is necessarily harmful, and when one explains this to any figure of authority (or anyone who generally disagrees that the library books should not be moved), they will have no choice but to justify

the harm done by the decision with the benefits that may replace those of book accessibility. However, this will lead us into a tautology.

In a cost-benefit analysis of the situation, the following is stated: students will have more to gain from increased study space than they will have to lose from removal of books because they do not use them anyway.

From this, we return to the beginning of this section of the letter to see the circular logic. First, in your (loose) connection of renovations to circulation rates, you cement the idea that it is the utility of space which motivates your decision, insinuating that students use study space but they do not use books. In a blackbox picture of the statement, i.e. without knowing how exactly the new study space will look, how exactly it would benefit students that would use it, nor what student library usage really looks like (we are not given any of this information anyway), the best argument one could make with the minimal amount of knowledge possessed starts with identifying usage of study spaces. The logic terminates in a circle, for this line of reasoning must be created from the "bottom-up" as Dr. Laguna would put it, that in UT admin deciding that they would like to concentrate their efforts on benefitting students, they would require something which would cause them to do so, being in this case student "needs" as discussed earlier. It does not matter the degree to which students would hypothetically benefit from more study space, as these benefits are hollow if there is already enough to go around; the benefits operate "depth first" as some might say rather than "breadth first". Furthermore, removing the library books will always present itself as a "cost", since eliminating an available resource removes that potential usage even if every student does not use it all of the time, while adding space does not always present itself as a benefit if it is not always in use (so it is actually the reverse of the initial statement that ends up being true). This takes us back to the very beginning in discussing how adding space is beneficial in the first place.

The tautological nature of the reasons behind the decision thus illustrates itself as follows: we assume that study space is needed AND we assume that we have to remove the library books in order to make more of this needed space, so we have to have justify why this would be a net benefit for students, but in order to show this, we must subsequently prove that a need for this space existed; however, this is exactly where we started. Once this is presented to someone like Dr. Laguna or anyone else who might agree that the library should be removed from PMA, they will shrug their shoulders and state that they have put their faith in the powers that be, and that we (students or faculty) should not have a say in what you or anyone else should decide as it pertains to the building's facilities. This blind trust stems from a deeper manipulation tactic related to scientific communication, and though we construct our analysis from default arguments necessitated by a lack of information, even in the case of full transparency, problems persist.

Dr. Laguna (and other administration apologists) will reference some kind of quantitative analysis that went into motivating this decision, which you hint at when you point out trends in library checkout rates (yet you never explicitly mention them), yet by solely looking at this metric, you not only completely ignore any other ways which people might use the library books, those ways being commonplace and integral to their academics and research, but additionally, by saying that checkout rates are low, you imply that if they were higher, then we would not have to remove the library. This begs the question of what appropriate checkout rates might look like:

is it once per day? Should it be once per hour? Is that what a library should look like? That books are constantly flying off the shelves, revolving in and out of circulation? Regardless of the answers to these questions, in bringing up quantitative metrics, then there must necessarily exist some threshold of book checkout rates which would not cause you to make this decision, and yet you do not put effort into meeting this number, to encourage more book checkouts; your idea is that we should remove the books from the building altogether.

What is truly irksome about this is that in alluding to quantitative analysis of any form, one likens themself to a scientist or a statistician, evoking an image of post-enlightenment lucidity and rationality, so people like Dr. Laguna and others would throw their hands up after one points out the illogical foundations of the decision and cover their eyes if we were to present any evidence that would contradict any of the findings that you claim to have. Just because anyone claims that a study has been done, this decision does not present itself as one of irrefutable scientific logic. Any scientist recognizes that you have committed a great sin when you invoked any kind of data or metrics yet did not choose to disclose them or your methodology for their collection; any scientist knows that a good study is unbiased and reproducible.

When Dr. Laguna told us to write this and to ask people what they think about the library closure, we decided to do so in the form of a petition. Of course, he did not make any promises as to the efficacy of any such efforts AND HE NEVER WOULD BE ABLE TO, for you have employed pseudoscience in your decision-making process, which is problematic given that people advocate for this decision as though it were scientific. By stating that you have come to some conclusion based on quantitative analysis, yet in withholding those metrics, you have shielded yourself from any evidence contradicting your findings. You say there is a "need" for more study space and that "circulation has been declining", yet if we were to show you a petition with X number of signatories saying that they want to keep the library as it is, it does not matter how high or low this number might be, for you never presented a number which would have defined your "need" for study space to begin with, and likewise it does not matter what REAL library usage may look like since you never defined what PROPER library usage should be in order for this decision to have not been made. This is pseudoscience by definition. As Bertrand Russell would say, this is equivalent to making the claim that "there is a teapot orbiting the Moon", but naturally any scientist would ask "how do you know?" The pseudoscientist responds "how do you know that it is not?" The burden of proof lies on the accuser; absence of evidence is not equivalent to evidence of absence.

It is only that vague allusions of statistics were invoked, and from there, that Dr. Laguna finds this decision to be logically sound as such. I am criticizing this particular aspect of your communication and not specifically whatever you might claim to conclude from any findings of any study. What I am trying to say is not that we expect every administrative decision to be strictly scientific or logical in that way, but in speaking as I have, I only mean to deconstruct the idea that this decision was in fact scientific and quantitative. In discussing this issue with administrators such as Dr. Laguna or with others, they would reference scientific analysis done on your part, and it is natural that what they might say would reflect equally upon yourself, for they are our closest connection to you. When we tell them that study space is not needed as admin would claim it to be or that library usage should encapsulate more

than simply book checkout rates, they would respond with something along the lines of "go collect data yourselves" or "show me data which says why the decision should NOT be made"; they want us to show that a teapot is not orbiting the Moon. I only mean to rebut against this point in the paragraphs which precede this one; the onus of data collection and presentation should be on YOU and the UT admin. When scientific claims are made, you open yourself up to such criticism.

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| Regarding the Creation of Offices |
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We will take time to address the creation of office spaces for the gravitational physics group in the upper level of the library. This alone is not so detestable of a decision. Many of us would agree that the Center for Gravitational Physics should be housed within PMA and not in Welch, and it is understood that office space in particular is limited in the building.

Let us for now ignore the fact that we have been promised a new building for the better half of twenty years and assume that we must move the gravity people to PMA as soon as would be possible, going so far as to undertake costly renovations (monetarily and temporally) so that we could do so. In all honesty, as useful as the journals are, it is true that their usage would not be obstructed by moving them to a storage facility; albeit, there is no doubt that doing this would slow the research of some, even if it would only be by a day or two as promised in the email announcement (though such promises are rarely kept in full). Were someone to need information from a journal, they would know exactly where to look. If the browsing of books is one of the main losses in removing them from the building, then it is noted that the activity of browsing journals itself is almost a complete gamble. People typically know what they are looking for when they choose to consult journals, i.e. the journal year, volume, and article author, so having the journal catalogue be available for online order would not be as devastating as removing the entirety of the PMA collections. This being said, the upper level of the library houses extra study space, a computer lab, and the gender neutral bathrooms (the only ones in the building besides those of the fourteenth floor), and all of these would be removed along with the journal stacks in order to create the new office space.

From this I propose the following: that the decision to remove the library is more logical in starting with the assumption that we need to move the gravity people out of Welch than to start by assuming that students need more study space. Though Dr. Laguna claims that the moving of his research group out of Welch was NOT the impetus for the removal of the library stacks, we believe that it is useful in considering this proposal because the losses begin with the journal stacks, which are not as highly valued as the lower level stacks, and the motivation begins with reuniting the physics department as opposed to the "need" for student study areas.

Previously, we have discussed the flow of logic of the decision for renovations given the contents of your email and the information from our discussion with Dr. Laguna. Of course, logic must flow downward, so to speak, that we start with some axioms, and with the given information, we use the machinery of logic to determine what it is that we should seek in the consequences of our decisions. From there, the decisions emerge from this logic on their own. Furthermore, the logic with the smallest amount of

assumptions is the strongest since our decisions should arise from logic itself rather than dogma (this is sometimes called Occam's razor). We have argued above that we require at minimum 3 dubious assumptions to make sense of your decisions, as given the announcement and our talk with Dr. Laguna, we could conclude no differently than we have, that these assumptions lead us in a circle, and we should note that making a decision based on a tautology is not only illogical but perhaps also sinful from anyone who claims to have done so logically. Our proposal, however, requires fewer assumptions, less work, and takes us in a straight line rather than a loop.

Let us start by assuming that we must move the gravity people from Welch to PMA ASAP (which itself is not an obvious assumption to make given what we know, as Dr. Laguna said that the decision to move his group back to PMA was completely separate from the removal of the library, that nothing drove him to do this other than perhaps the pleasing aesthetic of reuniting all of the physics groups within the building and possibly the obvious convenience of having all researchers in a department physically near to each other, but we are speculating, as he did not say any of this himself; however, it would be natural if, say, the departments housed in Welch wanted to use the space occupied by the gravity people, essentially kicking them back to PMA, but this is an unsubstantiated rumor). Next, we say that a decent place to make new offices would be in the upper level of the library since the journals are rarely used and their accessibility only slightly decreases in moving them (this point is debatable, but not completely wrong; it is at the very least worth discussing). But if we were to clear this space, then we would also be removing the study areas up there, and we would like to create new study space to replace it. It is logical to put study space removed from the library back in the library itself. The final task is to justify the removal of the remainder of the library books in order to conclude that we should make your decision.

Though we have done the work in dissecting any arguments in the final step, it is evident that in the logic laid out above, our decisions cascade downward from just one assumption, and it is possible that we might require no assumptions if we could easily show why the gravity group must move out of Welch sooner rather than later, with the real work being that we must demonstrate that the lower level shelves must be removed. Of course, this is just an example, but it is useful in considering this thought experiment since the removal of the journal stacks is not as contested as that of the rest of the library collections (but it should be noted that pushback is nonzero; see below).

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| Why the PMA Library Books Are Important |
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Regardless of whether the decision to remove the library stacks might contain some logic within it, and no matter how logical any decision in general might be, it is true that just because a decision is logical, that does not necessarily mean that it should be made. A good decision maker should resemble both Doctor Spock and Captain Kirk, for aside from the fact that a logic depends on initial assumptions, whose justification can easily be contested no matter what they might be, and that logic in general flows from common sense, which itself is taken for granted, a decision such as this symbolizes certain ongoing patterns in UT admin which warrant great

concern. To be specific, it is concerning that a decision which would affect the academic lives of so many students, faculty, and staff would be made with zero effort to consult these people and that efficiency, as it were, would take such high priority over scholarship. The first part of the letter was devoted to dissecting the logic behind the decision only because it claims to be logical, but regardless of whatever arguments one might propose in favor or against this decision, it is being made in extremely poor taste.

This last part of the letter will explain the emotional arguments, illustrating what is lost in removing the library, for as essential as it is to scholarship, it is also symbolic of the dedication to the pursuit of knowledge. We are not stating this for the purpose of arguing *per se*, but so that you may understand the real cost in a cost-benefit approach.

We start by describing how the PMA library books are immensely useful to students, in our out of PMA, who wish to learn about physics, mathematics, or astronomy, and it is surprising that this should require some explicit deliberation, for otherwise it would be clear that the books should not leave the building, but in today's age, information has become cheap. We take for granted that by pushing a few buttons on a keyboard, we have access to an endless stream of information, and within the last couple of years, barriers to knowledge on the internet have been broken down further (albeit only marginally) with publicly available large language models. Since all of this information can be stored remotely in some data center, then it is natural to ask why we need to keep space for books (ignoring for now that the creation of an increasing number of massive data centers is a separate issue). However, it is not the volume of information flow that measures its value, as information on the internet becomes increasingly unfiltered and likewise consolidated and controlled by tech corporations. Because of this, people are less attracted to the novelty of the world wide web and find appreciation for physical media. Books are not only written by people (for now), reviewed by experts, and refined through the publishing process, but you can take them anywhere, to places free from blue light screens and phone notifications; they are immortal, steadfast in their quality and usage in an era of constant and rapid change. Yet even with internet connection, many of the books in the library are not available online, for aside from the convenient accessibility of popular and well-known books (which in itself relieves financial stress on those who greatly rely on these types of standard texts), it is precisely this availability of obscure books that makes the PMA library such an incredible resource and it is what continually drives student usage. Many of us find books in the library which we have never heard of before, and from that book learn information which augments our knowledge and research in a way that never would have been possible without the library. Such instances cause us to go to the library on a regular basis, even if we do not check out a book.

Likewise the journal stacks in the upper level host articles that cannot be found on the internet (and perhaps nowhere else in the state of Texas), which contain information that materially contributes to our research. These relatively unknown texts are not ones which are in constant demand and circulate regularly, but they are available to us in our own building, and it is the fact that they are obscure which is being used as cause to remove them, the rationale being derived from supposed low circulation. Our departments stand out among other top tier research institutions, in part, because of the books, not in spite of them.

Because of the way that the decision is framed, it is impossible to extricate its nature from that of a thought process which prioritizes efficiency over anything else. It is of course efficient usage of space that forms the basis upon which rests the justification for removing the library books in the first place, for if we were allowed to use space inefficiently, then we would not have to question why the books should be allowed to take up the space they inhabit no matter how we characterize their modern day usage. The deceptive vice in this manner of decision making is that it is easy to convince oneself that it is an obviously logical choice. Typically, one does not ponder profoundly any decision which prioritizes efficiency because it is easy to claim that decisions which make some process more efficient and improves usage of a given resource are good ones, in this case that resource being space and the process perhaps being learning. At its core, this method of analysis assigns dollar amounts to the priceless value of knowledge and scholarship, and we have seen here at UT, elsewhere in Texas, and across the nation that using "efficiency" as the basis for administrative decisions has been used as an excuse to greenlight attacks on academic freedom. One draws a connection between the removal of libraries to that of the ongoing elimination of liberal arts departments.

Let us digress for a moment and talk about a larger campus issue, as it is important in illustrating what your decision symbolizes for the UT academic community, though I will keep my discussion of department elimination as brief as possible, as it is a whole other can of worms worth its own letter in unpacking. The department eliminations are naturally conducted from the standpoint of "efficiency", as it is even in the name "consolidation" that UT admin has been labeling it. Many have spoken out, saying that it is a clear attack on certain liberal arts departments such as the Women, Gender, and Sexuality Studies Department, the African and African Diaspora Studies Department, the Mexican American and Latina/o Studies Department, etc. whose existence has been characterized by the political far-right as a direct and deliberate offense to conservative ideas and as indoctrinating students into left-wing ideology; research in these fields, which consistently engages with the history of discrimination against marginalized groups in this country, is interpreted by the right as advertisement rather than scholarship. At the same time that admin would eliminate these departments for the sake of efficiency, they would create a new School of Computing, which would take various Computer and Data Science Departments and give them their own special resources to pursue their research. This policy move cannot be separated from the fact that "artificial intelligence" and machine learning research has been driving U.S. economic growth for the past year now. One views this as follows: that UT sees research in computer and data science as having a greater return on an investment than that of social studies; one gets their own resources while the other has theirs taken away and redistributed. What has been consolidated was the flow of resources, not "inter-departmental scholarship" or whatever excuse that admin will fabricate. They do not allow these departments demonized by the far-right to exist with autonomy. Given the forced disbanding of the faculty council and limitations of student activism under state law, UT admin, whose appointments trickle up to the seat of the governor, comes off as knowingly making an unpopular decision, as the voices of students and faculty in these departments have been not only ignored but actively suppressed. It is shameful that an academic institution would bend over for politicians so easily. The purpose of a university is not to serve

political interests.

And so, in your decision, you characterize the pursuit of knowledge and its availability as a waste of resources in the same way that admin has been doing so for academia in social studies departments. Last semester, when the white house sent the compact to UT along with 8 other universities, it was stipulated in the document that certain social studies departments be eliminated like the ones that have so far been discussed and that "hard science" programs should receive extra benefits and funding arguing as such from the standpoint of efficiency and return on investments. At the time, I wrote to you in a different letter back in November of 2025 that despite this appearing as though it would benefit CNS, that we should not let ourselves be misled down a dangerous path just because we may be promised a pot of gold at the end of it, that it would only be a matter of time before the federal government determines that programs in the sciences would be in ideological or financial conflict with their goals. UT never signed the compact, though they were the only university which did not publicly criticize and reject it, going so far as to have the university's president go on record to say that he did not think it was a big deal, blatantly mischaracterizing the gravity of the situation; yet they did not sign it only because they did not feel the need to sign a document listing policies which they already had the intent of implementing. I did not think it would be so soon that the physical sciences would be under attack in the same way that the social studies departments are.

Having examined the ideological connections of "consolidation" to that of the library's removal, the manner of decision making in these two is also similar. Neither you nor Dr. Laguna felt the need to consult anyone else in making the decision, going beyond omitting information but purposefully withholding it when directly asked. As a result, we had to canvas opinions after the announcement, collecting over 1000 signatures on a petition in opposition to the library renovations as they currently stand. Despite this, we have dealt with pushback from our own department chairs on advertising our petition, with aggressive emails and overt censorship. We sympathize with the social studies departments in this regard.

Seeing as we nor the faculty have any say in the appointment of deans or other administrators, we find that it is the duty of our departmental chairs to advocate for our interests to the upper level admin on our behalf, as we have no direct means of ensuring that they represent us. Admin has demonstrated that they would go forward with unpopular decisions against the will of faculty and students, and we would like to believe that it would be our chairs who would consult us and hear our opinions before approving decisions which might affect us so greatly as the removal of a library, for if admin were to make a decision of even greater magnitude, it is distressing that we would not be able to trust our chairs as acting on behalf of our interests as opposed to acting as individuals.

According to Dr. Laguna, proposals for library renovations have been brought to the PMA departments in the past, and he had wished for a long time that something different would be used for that space, but it was the late legendary physicist, Nobel laureate Dr. Steven Weinberg, the lion of PMA, who insisted that the library be kept, and UT admin listened to him at the time. He understood the inherent and priceless value of knowledge, scholarship, and academic freedom, and it is a shame that we would go against his wishes so soon after his passing.

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| Conclusion and Summary |
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The library books should not be removed. We are reluctant to make any concessions, and we would be swallowing a spoonful of pure salt if we were to presuppose that we should bargain down just because we might think that this decision is not reversible. It is true that people in the PMA community are not so opposed to the removal of the journal catalogues to the Life Sciences library or Pickle Research Center as they are to the rest of the books. We are opposed, however, to the reasons behind the decision as you have laid them out, and the manner in which it was made, being that it was done without consulting the PMA community at large, and as I write this, there are well over 1000 signatures to a petition expressing exactly this.

In the same way that the decision to eliminate gender and ethnic studies departments was made against the will of people in those departments while voices were suppressed and silenced, we find that this is connected in ideology and method with your decision to close the PMA library and that this is related in the same way to the closures of other libraries across campus. It is disturbing that the former of these decisions is one which serves the political interests of the far-right conservative Texas government.

Education should not be subject to decisions geared toward efficiency in the same way that a business would be. The stifling grind of university lies in contrast to the freedom offered by the library, where one can choose of their own accord the subjects that they wish to study, away from the rigid regulations, deadlines, and cutoffs of classrooms. In an age where one is increasingly drawn away from real life and towards screens, they lose interaction with the world around them; experiences on the internet are not ours, they are owned and controlled by our ISP's and tech corporations. We would be relinquishing autonomy and ownership of our experiences and agency in our education for "efficiency".

Continual decision-making from the standpoint of efficiency can only result in radical purging of essential resources. If future policy makers employ your logic, then one wonders what will happen to the books after they are moved from the building. Circulation will inevitably decrease as they become increasingly inaccessible, and when it drops to zero, they would be perceived as a waste of space no matter where they were put; at that rate we might as well burn them now and save ourselves the trouble of moving them.